

Ch11: Online Communities, Virtual Reality, And Artificial Intelligence

P3: AI, Humans, & Cyborgs



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Learning Objectives

Upon completion of this lesson the students should be able to:

- Explain how developments in Artificial Intelligence (AI) have affected our sense of self and our conception of what it means to be a human being
- Discuss the issue of whether certain types of AI entities warrant moral consideration

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3. Artificial Intelligence (AI) and its Implications for What it Means to be Human

We can ask: Which criteria distinguish humans from other kinds of creatures and entities?

- Is **rationality** a plausible criterion?
- The view that only humans are rational has recently been challenged on two separate fronts:
 - 1) research in animal behavior/intelligence suggests that many primates, dolphins, and whales are capable of demonstrating skills we typically count as rational;
 - 2) developments in artificial intelligence (AI) have shown that certain forms of "rational activity" can also be attributed to computers.

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What is AI?

- John Sullins (2015) defines AI as "the science and technology that seeks to create intelligent computational systems."
- He notes that AI research has aimed at building computer systems that can duplicate, or at least simulate, the kind of intelligent behavior found in humans.

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AI Background/Developments (Continued)

- John Weckert (2001) articulates this kind of (sociological) concern when he asks:

Can we, and do we want to, live with artificial intelligences? We can happily live with fish that swim better than we do, with dogs that hear better, hawks that see and fly better, and so on, but things that can reason better seem to be in a different and altogether more worrying category...What would such [developments mean for] our view of what it is to be human?

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Can We build (Genuinely) Intelligent Machines? An Ongoing Debate

- We can ask whether it is possible, even in principle, to build "machines," i.e. either software programs or (physical) artificial entities, that are "genuinely intelligent" and whose intelligence could rival and possibly exceed that of humans.

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The Turing Test as a "Thought Experiment" for Machine Intelligence

- In 1950 Alan Turing predicted that by the year 2000, a computing machine would be able to pass a test, which has come to be called the *Turing Test*, demonstrating machine intelligence.
- Turing envisioned a scenario in which a person engaged in a conversation with a computer (located in a room that was not visible to the human) was unable to tell – via a series of exchanges – whether he or she was conversing with another human or with a machine.
- He believed that if the person could not be sure that this entity was a human or a computer, then we would have to attribute some degree of intelligence to the computer.

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The Turing Test and Searle's "Chinese Room" Argument

- Was Watson merely acting in a manner similar to the individual in John Searle's (now) classic "Chinese Room" thought experiment?
- In that scenario, a human who is a native English speaker but who understands nothing about the Chinese language is able to perform tasks that require manipulating Chinese symbols to produce correct answers to questions posed in Chinese.

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The Chinese Room Argument (Continued)

- Once the person inside the room has completed the task, he passes the answers through the slot to a person waiting outside.
- That person might assume that the individual who returned the correct answers understood Chinese.
- But Searle (1980) argues that it is possible that the person (inside the room) understood nothing about the semantic meaning of the questions he received and the answers he returned.

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The Turing Test- GPT, LLaMa

- A March 2025 study from UC San Diego researchers evaluated several AI systems in controlled, three-party Turing tests.
- GPT-4.5, when prompted to adopt a human-like persona, was judged to be human 73% of the time — actually more often than the real human participants.
- LLaMA-3.1 was judged human 56% of the time
- The researchers called it "the first empirical evidence that any artificial system passes a standard three-party Turing test."

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The "Chinese Room" Argument (Continued)

- The person in the "Chinese room," who is not seen by anyone outside that room, receives questions from someone who passes them to him through an opening or slot.
- That person then consults a series of instructions and rules located inside the room, all of which are written in English.
- The person is able to substitute the incoming Chinese symbols for other Chinese symbols in such a way as to produce correct answers to the questions asked.

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The Chinese Room Argument (Continued)

- Searle points out that the person in the room could merely have been following a set of syntactic rules (written in English) that were designed to manipulate symbols that happened to be in Chinese.
- In fact, it is possible that the English-speaking person (inside the room) may not even know that the symbols involved are elements of the Chinese language.

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Cyborgs and Human-Machine Relationships

- a) Are humans becoming more computer-like?
- b) Are computers becoming more human-like?
- We look at (a) from the perspective of AI-induced bionic chips.

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AI and Controversies Involving Bionic Chip Implants (Continued)

- Moor (2005) notes that while therapeutic implants will likely be accepted, “enhancement implants” will likely be controversial.

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AI and Chip Implants (Continued)

Additionally, Moor believes that such a policy would likely endorse the use of chip implants that:

- reduced dyslexia;
- assist memory of Alzheimer patients.

But Moor also believes that this kind of policy would not endorse the implanting of either a:

- “deep blue” chip for superior chess play;
- miniature digital camera that would record and playback what a person had just seen.

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Cyborgs and (AI-induced) Bionic Chip Implants: Are Humans Becoming More Computer-Like?

- Future chip plants made possible by AI could be designed to make a normal person “super human.”
- Weckert (2001) notes that “conventional” implants designed to “correct” deficiencies have been around and used for some time.
- The purpose of conventional, or “therapeutic” implants, has been to assist patients in their goal of achieving “normal” states of vision, hearing, heartbeat, etc.

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AI and Chip Implants (Continued)

- In other words, Moor believes that:
- therapeutic chip implants such as pacemakers, defibrulators, and bionic eyes that maintain and restore natural bodily functions will most likely be accepted;
- enhancement implants, such as giving patients added arms or infrared vision, will most likely be prohibited.

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Are We (Becoming) Cyborgs?

- Some now worry that with bionic parts, humans and machines could soon begin to merge into *cyborgs*.
- Ray Kurzweil (2000) suggests that the distinction between machines and humans may no longer be useful.
- James Moor (2005) believes the question we must continually reevaluate is not whether we should become cyborgs, but rather: *What sort of cyborgs should we become?*

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Are Computers Becoming More Human-Like (Continued)?

- Sophisticated robots of the future may not only look more human-like, but may also exhibit sentient characteristics.
- These robots, like humans and animals, could (arguably) have some **sentience** (and thus be capable of simulating the experiences of sensation, feeling, and emotion).
- Robots and other kinds of AI entities of the near future may also exhibit, or appear to exhibit, **consciousness**.

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Do (At Least Some) AI Entities Deserve Moral Consideration

- Three questions worth considering from Scenario 11-4 are:
 - 1) Should the artificial boy (or any artificial creatures like “him”) ever have been developed in the first place?
 - 2) Is it morally permissible for the “boy’s” adopted parents to discard “him” as they would some other kind of “computer resource”?
 - 3) Does this “boy” deserve (at least some) *moral consideration* (especially from the human parents who adopted “him”)?

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Expanding Our Sphere of Moral Consideration (Continued)

- Prior to the 20th century, we generally assumed (for whatever reasons) that *only* human beings deserved ethical consideration.
- All other entities—animals, trees, natural objects, etc.—were assumed to be mere *resources* for humans to use (and abuse) as they saw fit.

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Expanding Our Sphere of Moral Consideration (Continued)

- By the mid-twentieth century, the assumption that moral consideration should be granted only to humans was challenged by both:
 - animal-rights activists/groups,
 - environmentalists.

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Expanding Our Sphere of Moral Consideration (Continued)

- Animal-rights advocates point out that animals, like humans, are capable of feeling pain and suffering (i.e., they are **sentient**).
- Many of these advocates also argued that because animals can suffer, we should grant them moral consideration.

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Expanding Our Sphere of Moral Consideration (Continued)

- Influenced by the work of Hans Jonas (1984), some philosophers and many environmentalists have argued that we should also extend our realm of moral consideration to include:
 - **trees,**
 - **plants,**
 - **the entire ecosystem.**

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Expanding Our Sphere of Moral Consideration (Continued)

- Will some AI entities eventually qualify as *moral agents*?
- Even if AIs are unable to qualify as full-blown moral agents (as most adult humans do), they may nevertheless meet the threshold of what Floridi calls “moral patients.”
- In Floridi’s scheme, moral patients are “receivers of moral action” (while moral agents are the “sources of moral action” – i.e., capable of causing moral harm or moral good).
- Like moral agents, moral patients enjoy moral consideration and thus have at least some moral standing.
- Unlike moral agents, however, moral patients cannot be held morally responsible for their actions.

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